

So you're thinking about journalism

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We're going to be straighter with you here than in any other one of these, because you deserve the actual numbers rather than a softened version.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. Desk journalism — rewriting, aggregating, routine news production — came out at **8.3 out of 10**.

Investigative reporting came out at **5.1**.

But here's the thing our score misses, and it matters more: journalism's problem was never mainly AI.

The 60-second version

- The industry has shrunk roughly **60% since 2008**, almost entirely for economic reasons.
 - Around 95,000 students are enrolled in journalism programmes. There are 45,000–50,000 working journalists.
 - AI is now taking the desk work, which was the last cushion.
 - **The work itself is still worth doing**, and the protected end is real.
 - Which means the advice is narrow rather than "don't."
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The numbers, without softening

- Publishing employment: **91,000 jobs in the late 1990s** → **about 55,000 today**
- Reporters and correspondents: **~114,000 in 2008** → **45,000–50,000 now**
- Newspaper newsroom jobs fell **more than half between 2008 and 2020** (Pew)
- **~2,900 newspapers have closed** since 2005. Over 200 US counties have no local outlet at all.
- BLS projects editor roles growing about **1% a year**
- At least **3,434 journalism jobs cut** across the US and UK in 2025 — 2026 is running faster

None of that was caused by AI. It was classified ads moving to the platforms, advertising moving to search and social, and audiences fragmenting. That process finished before ChatGPT existed.

What AI is doing is removing the shock absorber. Desk work — rewriting wire copy, aggregating other outlets — survived the earlier rounds because someone had to do it. That's the part automating now.

The comparison that should decide this

Roughly **95,000 students** are enrolled in journalism and mass communication programmes in the US.

There are roughly **45,000–50,000 working journalists**.

Two students in the pipeline for every working journalist in the country.

That's not about talent. It's arithmetic, and it's why journalism graduates struggle even in years when nobody's cutting.

The practical implication: in this field the degree is abundant and *evidence of actually doing it* is scarce. Which shapes everything below.

What's actually protected

The good news, and it's real.

TRACK	SCORE
Investigative reporting	5.1
Specialist / trade reporting	5.8
Data journalism	6.5
General news reporting	6.7
Desk / aggregation	8.3

What protects journalism is exactly what always protected it: being in the room, being trusted by a source, and being legally answerable for what you publish.

A source risking their job talks to a *person*. Nobody has automated getting someone to tell you something they shouldn't.

The problem isn't that the protected work is unprotected. It's that there's less of it being paid for.

Where the work actually went

This is the constructive part, and it's more substantial than the headlines suggest.

Digital-native and subscription outlets have added an estimated 15,000+ roles since 2020. The economics that work now are subscriptions and memberships, not display ads.

Newsletters and independent publishing are a genuine route — a \$2 billion segment with 35,000+ active journalist-run publications. Some of the best-known reporters in the country now run their own.

Nonprofit newsrooms — ProPublica, The Marshall Project, Inside Climate News, local nonprofits — have kept hiring. They're competitive, pay less than commercial peers, and can't absorb anywhere near the number being laid off. Real jobs, not a solution.

Trade and specialist publications are smaller but viable, and short of people who genuinely understand a technical field.

And the biggest destination is adjacent. The PR-to-journalist ratio is roughly six to one. Communications and content absorb far more journalism graduates than newsrooms do.

Worth knowing that before you choose the degree, rather than after.

The question that actually matters

Do you want to write, or do you want to find things out?

Be honest with yourself, because this is the difference between journalism and content work.

If it's the *writing* — you like putting sentences together, you're good at it, people tell you so — that's genuinely valuable and it points at content, communications, copywriting or publishing. Those exist and pay better. They also score around 8.2, like marketing execution.

If it's *finding things out* — you want to know what actually happened, you're annoyed when someone won't tell you, you'd rather sit in a council meeting than write about one — then you're pointed at the protected end, and that end is real.

What we won't soften

Pay is low for the education required, and has been for a long time.

There is no ladder. One industry analyst put it bluntly: there's no ladder left to climb, only avoiding falling off. That's harsh and it's not wrong for the general-news end.

Precarity is permanent, not a starting phase. Average tenure at a single outlet has dropped to 3.2 years, from 5.1 in 2012. About 12% of working journalists hold a second job.

And going freelance takes 12–18 months to replace a staff salary. That's a real financial requirement most people your age don't have.

The one thing that changes your odds

Start publishing now. Before the degree. This year.

A newsletter. A local beat nobody covers. A specialist blog about something you actually know.

With two students per working journalist, the degree is not what separates you. Evidence of doing the work is. And almost nobody your age has any.

It also answers a question no amount of thinking will: whether you'll actually do this when nobody is making you.

Where AI genuinely helps you

Journalism is the one profession where AI increases demand for the thing it can't do.

As the volume of unverified content rises, being able to establish what's actually true becomes more valuable, not less. That's journalism's central skill, and it's appreciating.

Practically: use the tools for transcription, document search and first-pass research — investigations involve enormous amounts of material. And **algorithmic accountability** — AI in public services, automated decisions, where these systems fail — is a badly under-covered beat that barely existed five years ago.

Does this actually sound like you?

It suits people who:

- **Get people to talk to them.** Largely untrainable, and obvious in people who have it.
- Are curious about **other people's lives**, not about writing
- Are comfortable **being unwelcome** — asking things people don't want to answer
- Are **stubborn**. Most stories are refusals until they aren't.
- Can accept **insecurity as permanent**

Harder if you need financial stability early, find rejection draining, or are drawn to the *idea* of journalism from films rather than the daily reality of it.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **Original reporting, or content production?** The single biggest distinction.
- **Do students publish in real outlets, from year one?**
- **Are verification, public records and media law taught properly?** Those are the durable skills.
- **Can you develop a specialist beat?** Specialists are hiring. Generalists aren't.
- **Where do graduates work — by name of outlet?** Not "in media."

And consider a subject degree plus journalism training instead. Knowing health, climate, courts or finance properly is often worth more than a journalism degree on its own.

Two things worth doing

Read the Press Gazette job cuts tracker. It's a running log of every announced cut and it's uncomfortable. Spend an hour with it before committing three years and a lot of money.

Then find a journalist two to five years in — not a famous one — and ask what their week actually looks like and what they earn.

One honest thing at the end

People keep entering a contracting industry, and it isn't irrational.

Journalism is one of very few careers where the work itself — finding out what happened and telling people — is straightforwardly worth doing. That's real, and no score measures it.

But choose it with the numbers in front of you rather than despite them. And choose the version that still exists: specialist, investigative, or a beat you know better than anyone else your age.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- [Journalism job cuts in 2026 — the tracker](#) — read this one first. It's a running, sourced log. Uncomfortable and current.
 - [Where the journalism jobs actually are](#) — the migration story: which sectors are hiring and which aren't.
 - [Journalism jobs 2026: how to get hired](#) — newsletters, nonprofits and specialist outlets, and what they actually want.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the industry economics in detail, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.